



KALRA (IN ORANGE) WITH THE MAKEMYTRIP.COM TEAM ON A VACATION ON THE BANKS OF RIVER KALI IN UTTARAKHAND

about 2001. "We just had two months of capital left. It was almost like you're standing and someone punches you in the solar plexus and you try to stand again and someone punches you again." But he could clearly see the business going ahead, so decided to hang with it. When he told his team, about one-third of his people left. "I told my colleagues, this is our plan. If you don't believe we can make it, you can go," he remembers. The senior team, which stayed on, took big pay cuts—Kalra himself went 18 months without a salary—and was even forced to buy back equity with their life savings. "There was no great Plan B. We would have to close down and go back to the corporate world. Moreover, there were these 24 guys who implicitly trusted me, and that's the only thing that kept me up

at night," he recalls.

Today, this former banker, who also dabbled in building bowling alleys, is having the last laugh. He says, he always knew he did not want to be a banker. The most clichéd thing for the CEO of an online travel company would be to say that he loves travelling, but Kalra has a stock of whacky adventures to

tell. He has come face-to-face with a reef shark while scuba-diving, seen a leopard attack a forest ranger in Kenya a few feet away and has swum, well, inebriated, in a river during an offsite with the "Trippers" (that's what the MMR guys are called). "In these eight years, my wife hasn't heard me complaining that I hate what I'm doing. I'm having the time of my life. How many people can say that?"

by Nandini Vaish

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SCUBA-DIVING, SEEN A LEOPARD ATTACK A FOREST RANGER IN KENYA JUST A FEW FEET AWAY AND HAS SWUM ACROSS A RIVER WHILE INEBRIATED, WITH HIS COLLEAGUES.